CASE STUDY · LANCASTER, PA

Lancaster, PA: the AI Hub

A $10 billion AI data center announcement caught the community by surprise. The City of Lancaster negotiated the nation's first data center-related community benefits agreement, then rewrote its zoning code.

A case study by the Grade My Data Center research team

KEY TAKEAWAYS

What this case teaches

For local policymakers

- **Use your leverage before permits are final.** Lancaster had no data center zoning, but the developer still needed permits. The City turned a two-page list of non-negotiables into an enforceable agreement.
- **A CBA can reach further than zoning.** Lancaster's agreement caps water use, requires 100% clean energy with fines, adds $20 million in community funds, and binds future owners. Zoning cannot require payments or clean energy. Zoning governed where data centers could be built and set building standards.
- **Write data center zoning before the next project.** Without it, the AI Hub was approved under wholesale trade and storage rules. The City passed its own data center ordinance 7–0 a year later.
- **Don't sign NDAs, and share what you know.** The City published the signed CBA, FAQs, and a complaint process.

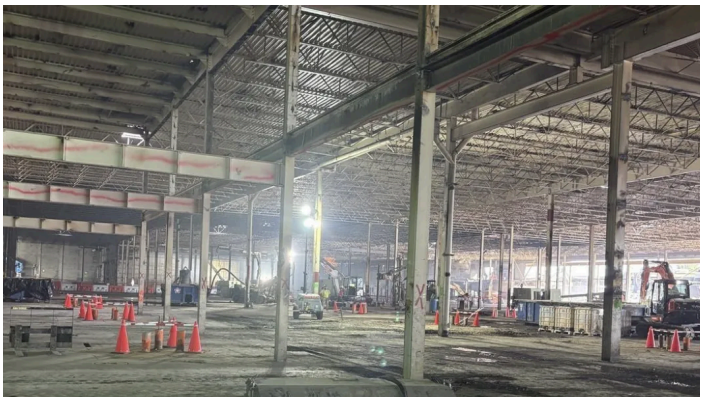
For communities

- **Ask early who is behind a project.** Most residents first heard about the AI Hub from a national announcement, months after the buildings were bought.
- **Ask for a seat at the table.** Residents were not directly a part of the CBA negotiation. That is the main criticism of an otherwise widely praised deal.
- **Look closely at the numbers.** The $20 million in community funds is 0.2% of a $10 billion investment. Ask how promises will be reported and enforced.









“We have numerous questions”

On July 27, 2025, a headline in the Lancaster, PA, local newspaper read, “We have numerous questions about the new data center planned for Lancaster city.”[1]

Just 12 days before, U.S. President Trump, the governor of Pennsylvania, and the CEO of server company CoreWeave had announced a $6 billion investment in the “Lancaster AI Hub,” two hyperscale-size data centers in the small city of Lancaster, PA. It was part of a series of announcements during U.S. Senator Dave McCormick’s inaugural Pennsylvania Energy & Innovation Summit, where companies, electeds, and investors came together to announce more than $90 billion of investments in energy and AI in Pennsylvania.[2]

The announcement spurred immediate reactions from local residents and businesses. This was the first time many in Lancaster were hearing about the data centers. What was the investment? Who was making it? Who asked the community if this was okay? Would the community benefit? If so, how would the community benefit? What would the impacts be on jobs, local air pollution, and quality of life? And why was this the first time anyone was hearing about it?

It wasn’t the first time Lancaster’s mayor was hearing about it, though. Earlier that year, there had been another newspaper article about an investor purchasing two, shuttered, former printing press facilities for an undisclosed price. The investor, Machine Investment Group (MIG) had mentioned converting them into artificial intelligence (AI) data centers, but no one really knew what those were or what impact they might have. With the news from President Trump, Governor Josh Shapiro, and CoreWeave, then-Mayor Danene Sorace, the City staff, and the local economic development organization realized they would need to spring into action to negotiate local benefits from these now-nationally known and strategically important investments.[3]

The Lancaster AI Hub

The “Lancaster AI Hub” would replace two, shuttered, former printing press facilities. When the facilities closed, they laid off 650 workers, and left two large buildings vacant. While other prospective buyers in the past had expressed interest to the City and Mayor about redevelopment, many had suggested distribution warehouses – which didn’t interest the Mayor because of traffic considerations and lack of high paying jobs.

This developer team, including MIG and Blue Owl Capital, the investors; Chirisa Technology Parks (Chirisa), an Irish company and the real estate developer; and CoreWeave, the server company and eventual tenant, had proposed the “Lancaster AI Hub” instead.[4] Plans showed three data center buildings across two campuses totaling 144 acres, with one campus known as “Lancaster AI Hub East” and the other as “Lancaster AI Hub West.”[5]

Lancaster AI Hub East would come first, including the partial demolition and adaptive retrofit of an existing 400,000 square foot facility (the former printing facility) plus the construction of a second, 650,000 square foot building. The location is adjacent to a six-lane highway and in a neighborhood with other industrial uses: truck repair services, a railroad, a tobacco supplier, and High Steel Structures LLC, which employs 500-750 people on an 85-acre assembly yard. Roughly a year later, the team proposed to start Lancaster AI Hub West, a 1 million square foot building. Lancaster AI Hub West would border a city park, two rail lines, a U.S. Postal Service processing and distribution center, a solid waste management facility, and the athletic fields of a nearby college.

Although MIG bought the buildings for just $130 million in February 2025, the team of four companies would invest more than $10 billion in the campuses. CoreWeave committed $6 billion and the other three partners, another $4 billion. Combined, the two projects would have a total power draw of 350MW, 130MW to power Lancaster AI Hub East and 220MW to power Lancaster AI Hub West.[6] The projects would require new grid infrastructure, so the developers pledged up to $200 million to PPL Electric Utilities for infrastructure upgrades that would be completed on- and off-site.[7] The buildings would utilize closed-loop cooling systems with magnetic-levitation chiller systems, and have 72 diesel back-up generators equipped with Selective Catalytic Reduction (SCR) systems to reduce emissions. The team projected that the investments would create 600-1,000 jobs during construction and up to 350 permanent positions.

How to negotiate a data center

Fortunately for the City of Lancaster, speed was on their side. Now that the investments were publicly announced, the developers were motivated to start construction.

The developers had submitted renovation plans for Lancaster AI Hub East to the City of Lancaster for their approval. Like many places, the City had no zoning ordinances or permitting processes specific to data centers. Moreover, the State of Pennsylvania requires that every local government allow all legal property uses somewhere within their boundaries.[8] Confronted with the plans, City staff had to approve the buildings under the existing wholesale trade and storage designations, understanding that data centers were indeed different from those other uses but lacking any regulatory authority to treat them differently.

Led by then-Mayor Danene Sorace, the City quickly entered into negotiations with the developer about the data center campuses. Although the developer owned the land and had submitted plans for one of the two properties, they had not yet secured their permits on the first property, let alone the second. The Mayor and City recognized a closing window

where the lack of a local zoning ordinance might actually work in their favor: an enforceable agreement on the conditions for the development might yield much more than zoning alone.

During initial conversations with the team at Chirisa, the Mayor had found that they exhibited a level of transparency unfamiliar to deals with Corporate America. As a European company, they were comfortable with strict regulatory environments and sustainability requirements. They were also open to negotiations. In Lancaster, Chirisa had found sites at the right cost and with the right power and fiber availability for their already-engaged tenant. Like other data center developers, speed was of the essence.

When the City presented a two-page list of non-negotiable requirements, there was surprisingly little pushback. Quickly, the Mayor worked with Lancaster City Council and Chirisa and MIG to negotiate details of a community benefit agreement (CBA) using that two-page list of non-negotiables.[9]

The nation's first data center-related community benefit agreement

A CBA is a legal agreement between a developer and another entity, sometimes public, sometimes private, that establishes legal requirements for the development, plus penalties when those legal requirements are violated. They have historically been used by private developers making major infrastructure investments into both rural and urban places. Often, they are intended to offset the disruption of the investment - its construction and also its operation - with explicit benefits to the nearby communities. Importantly, though, there is no general norm or regulation for a data center CBA. While researchers have gathered databases with good examples, CBAs remain a flexible, highly local, and highly customized tool. And one that states sometimes legislate against localities from negotiating.[10]

For the City of Lancaster, this would not only be its first CBA, it would also be the country's first data center-related CBA. That made coming up with the contents of the CBA challenging. City officials had to quickly come up to speed on what to include despite lacking technical expertise. Without another data center-related CBA, they also could not rely on a "template" on which to improve or revise.

A small team of the mayor, the city solicitor, a few city staff, and Council President and Vice-President drafted the CBA. This was reviewed by a national law firm and informed by two engineering firms with expertise in air quality and noise mitigation. The law firm had expertise working with data centers representing both communities and developers, and provided input and guidance on the draft. They would represent "the City", while the owners (Chirisa, CoreWeave, and MIG) would be represented by their project holding company. This was unusual but not unheard of, as CBAs are traditionally signed by private developers and private organizations, non-profits or community groups that represent a set of individuals locally.

The 32-page draft CBA would be wide-ranging. It includes everything from a commitment to reduce water usage to a 20,000 gallon daily cap per campus – 80 percent less water than the printing plants – to a commitment to use 100% clean energy - and pay fines if clean energy thresholds are not met by certain dates.[11] The CBA also requires the developer to pay $20 million in two, $10 million funds - one for sustainability and one for local economic development. The two funds would be administered by different parties, and would go towards initiatives determined by local bodies. Importantly, they represented a clear departure from the developer's initial informal offer of funding: $25,000 to the local fire department.

Design considerations proved critical to the CBA's content. Long sections of the CBA describe in technical language noise measurement and allowances, landscaping and tree canopy, how the data center could be viewed (or not) from the nearby roads, and how light affected local inhabitants and wildlife. Also critical were environmental impacts. The CBA references limiting air pollution, energy usage, thermal heat, and water and wastewater use from the two Hubs, and provides for decommissioning of the buildings and the data center equipment. These considerations survive owners: if / when the property is sold, the legal commitments pass from the current owners to future ones.

Updates regarding negotiations were provided at City Council meetings by either City Council President and/or the Mayor. A draft was presented in mid-October and a final document was presented just before a special meeting on Nov. 20, 2025, expressly for the purpose of reviewing the CBA.

Although no community members were directly involved in the negotiation, even before the CBA was signed, the developer established a public website with important information, held a community open house to answer questions, and committed to a Local Hiring Plan and fair wages. Hosted in Downtown Lancaster, the community open house operated like a school fair, with consultants hosting tables of information and answering questions. The City also published a website with FAQs and the signed CBA, and set up a formal complaint-response process with the developer.

How much citizen oversight is enough oversight

But for some residents, these efforts were not enough. As the Mayor and City Council were negotiating the CBA, a local resident appealed the City's zoning decision. Their argument was that the developer had violated zoning rules by proposing data centers in an area zoned for wholesale trade and storage.[12] The developer counter-sued to continue construction.

The case was ultimately ruled in favor of the developer. Without changes to the zoning code, future data centers essentially had by-right approval in the City, meaning they did not have to receive additional permitting or City or community scrutiny before going through other approvals, then construction. This would need to change.

Furthermore, some city residents believed they should have been involved directly in the details of the CBA negotiations, rather than simply weighing in on the Mayor's updates during City Council meetings or attending the developer open house. Although City staff had not signed non-disclosure agreements (NDAs) with the developers, negotiations had taken place largely behind closed doors. Some city residents questioned this, especially in light of Lancaster's generally inclusive community engagement processes. How much citizen oversight is enough oversight remains a question largely unanswered for data center development nationwide.

Zoning for data centers

The CBA would ultimately govern the development of Lancaster AI Hub East and Lancaster AI Hub West, as well. However, to avoid future conflict on data center developments, the City would need to amend its zoning code to add language specific to data centers.[13]

Again, the City of Lancaster was in uncharted territory. The City had just published a new Comprehensive Plan for the first time in decades, but data centers had not yet been an issue. When the City Council directed the City Solicitor to draft a zoning amendment for data centers just three weeks after the Lancaster AI Hub announcement, it was still among the

first zoning amendments from local governments in the country. Over the next year, the City Solicitor and City staff would collaborate to develop the amendment, seek public comment, revise the amendment, and present it to the City Council. In July 2026, a year after the Energy Summit announcement, the ordinance passed by a 7-0 vote. Seven months before, the Council had adopted the CBA by a 6-1 vote.

The amended ordinance governs where data centers can be built, how they sound, what they look like, and what types of energy they use. It allows developments only in the "suburban manufacturing" district, or 16 parcels in the northeast corner of Lancaster, of which none have the space and electricity capacity for a data center.[14] The zoning amendment builds on the CBA by developing thresholds for pre- and post-construction noise, back-up power equipment, setbacks, fencing, and screening. It requires independently verified plans for energy management, water utilization, electronic waste and decommissioning, heat mitigation, and emergency response. It also enforces testing and reporting. The process of approving data centers must also include public informational meetings held prior to zoning or planning commission reviews. And it includes information about what types of (native) trees and shrubs to plant.[15] In sum, it mirrors as much of the CBA as possible (zoning cannot require financial contributions, clean energy commitments, or payments in the form of penalties.)

What's next for Lancaster

Across Pennsylvania, the Lancaster AI Hub and other proposed and under construction data centers have become lightning rods for community protest. State representatives have put forward legislation to allow for a temporary moratorium on data centers, and statewide surveys show almost three-quarters of Pennsylvanians would say no to data center development in their communities.[16]

On Aug. 18, 2026, even the formerly pro-AI, pro-data center Gov. Josh Shapiro reversed course. His executive order removes data centers from a fast-track permitting process, prohibits the use of NDAs for data center projects, and requires data center projects to meet rigorous Governor's Responsible Infrastructure Development (GRID) requirements before receiving state approval to proceed.[17],[18] GRID requirements require developers to bring their own power generation, meet clean energy requirements, fund electricity infrastructure, exceed environmental standards, and work with communities on engagement and community benefits.[19]

Meanwhile, a new mayor is now in place in Lancaster, and planning for how to spend the $20 million from the CBA continues. As construction ramps up on Lancaster AI Hub East, the developer reports $80 million of initial contracts awarded to regional businesses, employing 90% local labor and 60% small and disadvantaged businesses.[20] The developer had paid a transfer tax to the City of roughly $330,000 when they bought the properties. They will pay $7.8 million to the City in building permits – and perhaps more. When the City and County reassess properties in 2027, they will find out what new property taxes they owe on their $10 billion investment – having never received any tax breaks or incentives from the City.[21]

Locally, residents still contest how open and transparent the CBA negotiation process was - or should have been. The amended zoning ordinance might protect against future data center developments, but some residents wish the data centers had never been approved at all.

Nevertheless, the City's CBA has become a national case study on what to include in a data center-related CBA. Multiple non-governmental organizations (NGOs) cite the Lancaster example, and draw template CBA language from its

completed form.[22] Champions of the Lancaster CBA point to it being the nation's first data center-related CBA, thereby setting an important precedent for developers that CBAs can be used with data centers. Critics argue that residents and community groups should have been included in negotiating the CBA, the CBA should have had stronger reporting and enforcement provisions, and the developers should have contributed more than $20 million in community funds, or 0.2% of the $10 billion total investment.

Nationwide, time has changed things. While data center development began unfettered, local movements against data centers have propelled state-level shifts in policy and potential national repercussions in mid-term election results. Tax breaks for developers and NDAs with electeds used to be the norm; now, local residents and governments are pushing back with data center moratoriums, new zoning ordinances, and stronger, more expensive, and sometimes mandated CBAs. Back in Lancaster, local residents and electeds wonder what their role has been in changing the tide. When they initially negotiated their CBA, it was out of necessity, not to be the nation's first. They hope that what they produced will ultimately serve as the floor for a wave of data center-related CBAs, not the ceiling.

Notes

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According to interviews conducted under Chatham House Rules
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Chirisa Technology Parks, **https://www.prnewswire.com/news-releases/lancaster-ai-hub-unveils-new-local-economic-impact-data-302560798.html**
City of Lancaster website, **https://www.cityoflancasterpa.gov/blog/frequently-asked-questions-2027-reassessment/**
Climate Mayors, **https://www.climatemayors.org/data-centers-case-studies**

GRADE MY DATA CENTER ANALYSIS

Our scorecard review: Lancaster AI Hub

This part is separate from the case study above. Our research team filled out the Short Scorecard for this project ourselves, then looked at what the answers say about it.

The project we scored: a quick recap

WHERE Two former printing plants on industrial land in the City of Lancaster	**WHO** MIG and Blue Owl (investors), Chirisa (developer), CoreWeave (tenant)
SIZE 3 buildings on 2 campuses, 144 acres, about 2 million sq ft	**INVESTMENT** More than $10 billion
POWER 350 MW: 130 MW East, 220 MW West	**EQUIPMENT** Closed-loop cooling, 72 diesel backup generators
JOBS 600 to 1,000 construction, up to 350 permanent	**STATUS** CBA signed Nov. 2025; Hub East under construction

How we graded it

We used publicly available information via the City and developer websites and local newspaper (the LNP), plus on-the-ground interviews with local officials and community members, to complete this scorecard – akin to the level of information a determined resident or advocate would be able to access about the project.

See all 20 answers

Project Transparency & Community Engagement — 6.5 of 8 points

1.	I know why this Data Center Project is being built here.	I don't know
2.	I know who is developing the proposed Data Center Project.	Yes

3.	I know who to ask when I have questions about the Data Center Project.	Yes
4.	Project representatives have hosted opportunities to meet community members.	Yes
5.	My local government has not signed an NDA (non-disclosure agreement) with the developer.	Yes
6.	It is easy to find information from multiple sources about the positive and negative impacts of the Project.	I don't know
7.	The developer and local people seem to be working well together.	I don't know
8.	The developer has signed a CBA (Community Benefits Agreement) or something similar.	Yes

Impacts to Energy Bills, Local Water, & Noise

6 of 8 points

9.	The developer has told the public how much energy the Data Center Project will use.	Yes
10.	I've been informed as to where energy for this Data Center Project will come from.	Yes
11.	I've been informed as to how the Data Center Project will impact my electricity & gas bills.	Yes
12.	I've been informed about possible air pollution from the Data Center Project.	Yes
13.	The developer has committed to NOT increasing air pollution in my area.	No
14.	The developer has told the public how much water the Data Center Project will use.	Yes
15.	I've been informed as to how this Data Center Project will affect local water quality.	No
16.	The developer has told the public about possible noise from the Data Center Project.	Yes

Quality of Life

2.5 of 4 points

17.	The developer has committed to hiring local people and creating local jobs.	Yes
18.	The Data Center Project is located in an area with other industrial or manufacturing buildings and not next to schools, hospitals, or local shops.	Yes
19.	I am aware of what will happen to this Data Center Project if the developer decides to sell the Project or close it.	No
20.	This Data Center Project will benefit my community.	I don't know

15 out of 20

13 Yes | 4 I don't know | 3 No | 0 Not answered

Yes = 1 point · I don't know = ½ point · No = 0

What worked

- No NDA. The City shared information on its own website and the developer's, and held a public open house.
- A signed CBA with a water cap, 100% clean energy with fines, noise, light and landscape rules, and $20 million in local funds.
- Local hiring: the developer reports 90% local labor on early contracts.
- Reuse of former printing plants on industrial land, instead of building on open land.
- Required plans for e-waste and for decommissioning within 30 days of leaving.

Concerns

- Residents were not part of the CBA negotiation, and it was signed with the developer's shell company.
- No commitment to not increase air pollution, with 72 diesel backup generators at one site in a region with poor air quality.
- No information on how the project could affect local water quality.
- Community funds plus infrastructure spending are about 2.2% of the $10 billion investment.
- We could not yet see what happens if the project is sold or closed (question 19).

Still unclear

- Why the project came to Lancaster was never fully explained.
- Whether the developer and residents are working well together, and whether the project will benefit the community, depend on who you ask.
- Effects on electricity bills are set regionally by PJM, not locally.
- No job training or workforce programs have been announced.

Our discussion of the results

Overall, the Lancaster AI Hub scores (relatively) well on the Data Center Scorecard, with 15 points out of a total 20. A score of 15 points indicates that information about the project has been shared with community members, and community members may want to ask additional questions about answers that were "no" or "I don't know."

Project transparency

While there might not have been clarity about why the Data Center Project was proposed for Lancaster, PA, local officials worked quickly with the developer (albeit after the public announcement) to make the Project more transparent. Notably, local officials also did NOT sign a nondisclosure agreement (NDA) with the developer. Instead, they established a City website and a developer website, held an open house with the Project engineering and design consultants, and shared details about the Project location, specifications (like the size and design renderings of the project), and some of the

potential impacts. This is the minimum local officials and developers should do to establish transparency around proposed projects.

Community engagement

Local officials instead signed a community benefits agreement (CBA), which tackled many of the topics that concerned the community the most and disclosed additional information about the project itself. In the CBA, the developer commits to "clean energy" (low or no carbon emissions), water maximums, noise limits, light restrictions, and landscape screening. They also committed $20 million to two local funds for sustainability and economic development, which will be controlled by the City and by a separate, non-profit foundation. This is above and beyond the $200 million the developer will pay for infrastructure upgrades related to the transmission and distribution of electricity for the data center campuses.

The community funds plus the infrastructure investment still represent just 2.2% of the total $10 billion investment in the project. The developer will also pay real estate transfer fees, permit fees, and property taxes, but – is that enough? When the developer stands to profit so much from two campuses, what is the appropriate amount or percentage of community benefit?

Importantly, community members were not involved in the negotiation of the CBA, and the CBA was signed between the City of Lancaster and the developer's shell company for the project. A better process might be to involve members of the community in the CBA negotiation, and to ensure that there are sufficient City resources to enforce the CBA, if violated.

Impacts to energy bills, local water, and noise

Information about how much power each campus will draw has not been made publicly available for both campuses. Like with many data center projects, local residents are not clear about the impacts of the Data Center Project on their electricity and gas bills: bill adjustments are decided at a regional scale – in this case by PJM, the power grid operator for the region.

The CBA binds the developer to using 100% "clean energy" for the projects by 2030, and enforces fines if the developer does not meet those projections. This is a good thing, even if "clean energy" includes offsets or renewable energy credits (RECs) that compensate for a grid electricity mix that includes fossil fuels. An even better outcome for the project might have been to include renewable energy generation and storage onsite, in addition to the grid connection, and to discuss how the buildings could optimize power consumption, rather than operating consistently at full power capacity.

Lancaster, PA, is a region with very poor air quality, given the level of surrounding industry, the number of farms and agricultural uses, and the region's geographic characteristics. Adding data centers into the mix, especially those that may run off diesel back-up generators, could further exacerbate air quality. The proposed plan for the AI Hub include 72 back-up generators for just one of the two sites.

The CBA caps water consumption at 20,000 gallons of water per day at each campus, or enough water to fill the average backyard swimming pool. There is no information about the impact of the data centers on water quality, other than a commitment to not putting chemicals into the water (one would have hoped that would not even have to be committed to!). Other developers of hyperscale projects, especially hyperscalers, have made commitments to "water positive" data center development, including replenishing local water sources through upgraded water retention infrastructure and other projects.

Local officials, including at the county and state level, should require data disclosure around the environmental impacts of data centers. This should include greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions, air pollutants, energy draw, water usage, water quality and diesel fuel consumption. Depending on the data point, the data should be disclosed at monthly, quarterly, or annual frequencies on an asset-by-asset basis. This will allow local officials to monitor and enforce the CBA and other local regulations and the public to have transparency around the impacts of data centers to their health and financial wellbeing.

Quality of life

In the CBA, the developer also committed to hiring local people and creating local jobs. The previous tenants had laid off 650 workers, so any new jobs would be new jobs. Based on their website, the developer has mostly made good on this promise, including hiring a regional firm for construction and bringing on local businesses. There is no mention of job training or workforce development programs, nor partnerships with local technical schools or community colleges.

For data centers, the rule-of-thumb is that 60% of the costs normally go towards what's inside the building (the servers), while just 40% goes to the building and what's outside (the property, the building, the heating and cooling systems, etc.). Unless Lancaster stands up server manufacturing as its next industrial venture, the investment will primarily go to out-of-state – or out-of-country – firms.

Lancaster AI Hub will be, in part, adaptive reuses of existing industrial facilities in existing industrial areas. This is far preferable to building anew on a greenfield, as the investment upgrades an existing facility on brownfield land rather than disrupting plants, animals, and soil porosity.

CoreWeave's lease on the property is for 20 years (a relatively long lease in data center terms), and because of the CBA and the new zoning ordinance, the developer has submitted and will submit plans for electronic waste and recycling and for decommissioning the properties within 30 days of vacating them. This is hugely important, as one of the largest questions in this sector is what will happen with data centers if the space requirements change, server design shifts, and local communities, often in rural places, are left with vast, ghost campuses. Reusing existing industrial facilities on brownfield sites as data centers may bring life to towns hit hard by the industrial twists and turns of the past century.

Questions 7 and 20 of the Scorecard are subjective – and the hardest to answer for researchers. Initial interviews with community members indicate that their responses depend on a variety of factors, including opinions about AI overall and not just data centers. They are also skewed by the lack of citizen engagement in the CBA negotiation process. While there was excellent reporting in the local newspaper as the Lancaster AI Hub stories unfolded, there was not a lot of official communication from the City government as the CBA was negotiated. And at least one of the local activist groups, Lancaster Stands Up, reported not being included in the negotiations.

Sometimes in local government, there is a tradeoff between speed and getting something done. Local officials have to make their own calculations as to what's most important for governing well and with public interest in mind. However, future negotiations between local officials and data center developers should consider how community engagement engenders trust and buy-in and what forms it might take during the data center process. For other types of developments, local governments – including Lancaster, have used citizen-advisory boards (paid groups of citizens who oversee projects or departments), ad hoc citizen advisory committees, virtual and in-person meetings, canvassing and surveys, design workshops, and a whole host of other tools to elicit community input into major projects. But data centers require a level of real-time negotiation with developers, outside experts, staff, and community that may necessitate new forms of community engagement – or, a dramatic slowing of the process for approval.